FICC Research
Global Macro

Global Macro Thoughts

The AI fear trade seems overdone

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The world at a glance

- A strong payroll report and moderate CPI, but weak retail sales
- The JPY and JGB markets stabilize, despite fiscal concerns over Japan
- The AI fear trade – sell first and ask questions later
- Making sense of it all

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The US macro outlook has improved – mostly [1]

- The payroll report was strong across the board, even if it went against recent data
  - Admittedly, January is a difficult month for estimates (seasonal exits, benchmark revisions, etc)
  - But U3 also moved lower; the Fed is unlikely to simply dismiss the print, even allowing for the risk of revisions

- Retail sales were lackluster in December, with downward revisions to prior months
  - But we still estimate a very solid 2.6% q/q saar increase in PCE in Q4, even after this print
  - In addition, private payroll income is now running at 5.8% saar, relative to 4.4% three months earlier

- US households will also get over $200bn in lower taxes (relative to 2025) thanks to the OBBB
  - In recent cycles, the BEA has often found new income that improves the savings picture
  - Hence, fears of a sudden collapse in consumption given the low savings rate seem overdone

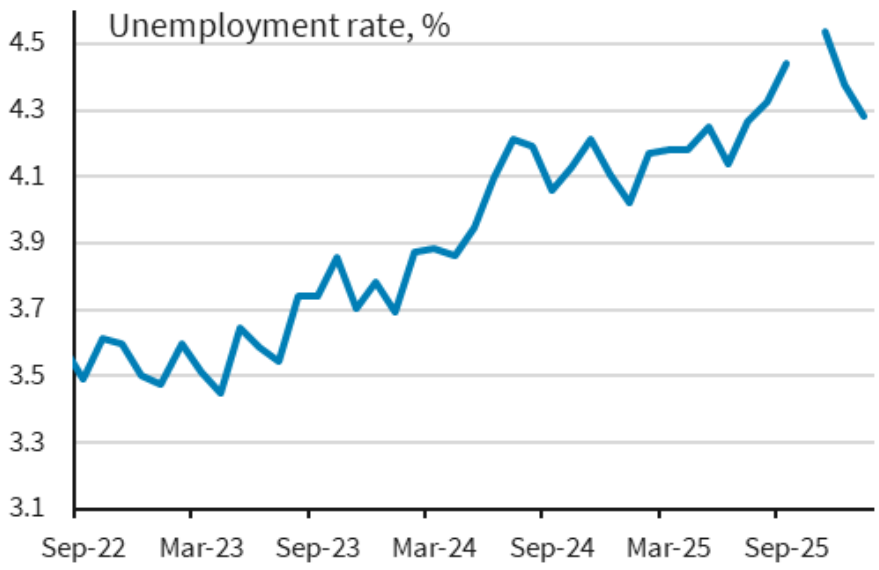
- Core CPI was up 0.3% m/m, below our (and market-implied) forecast of 0.4%
  - The headline was even weaker at 0.17% m/m, thanks to weak energy and food inflation
  - But some of the softness was idiosyncratic (used cars); core services inflation is still firm
  - We have softened our core CPI forecast slightly, to 2.8% (q4/q4 2026)

- We have also boosted our GDP growth outlook for Q2 and Q3 by 50bp each
  - Upgraded guidance by hyperscalers suggests another year of exponential AI capex
  - ***We now expect the US to grow at 2.5% q4/q4 saar in 2026; the US macro outlook remains positive***

[1] Global Economics Weekly: Sensory overload (13 February 2026)

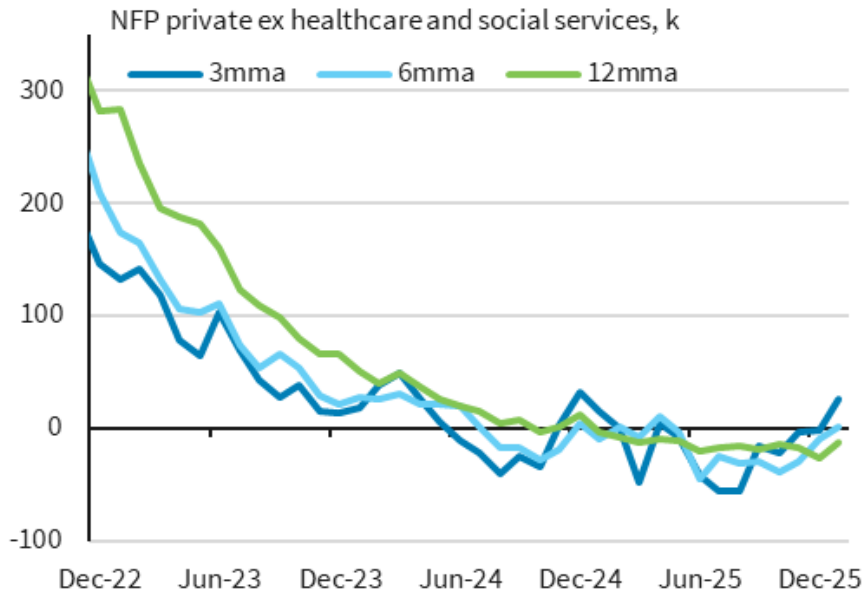
A reassuring payrolls report last week, with some caveats

The unemployment rate declined further, a welcome development for the FOMC



Source: Haver Analytics, Barclays Research
Global Rates Weekly: It's complicated (12 February 2026)

Excluding health care and social services, job gains nonetheless remain anaemic



Source: Hutchins Center, Barclays Research
Global Rates Weekly: It's complicated (12 February 2026)

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Japanese markets settle down, despite fiscal concerns [1]

- The initial reaction to the Takaichi landslide was strong equities, a weak JPY and higher JGB yields
  - But markets soon settled down, on the belief that any fiscal expansion would proceed cautiously
  - Takaichi's mandate reduces the need to compromise with opposition demands for wide-ranging spending
  - Markets believe this narrative; the JPY and long-end JGBs have both rallied since the election

- US pressure and market discipline will likely continue to weigh against strong fiscal expansion
  - In addition, the government doesn't seem to be pressuring the BoJ for easier monetary policy, so far
  - Hawkish BoJ member Tamura argued recently that rate hikes have so far had very little impact
  - He also said the BoJ still has considerable distance to go to get to the neutral interest rate

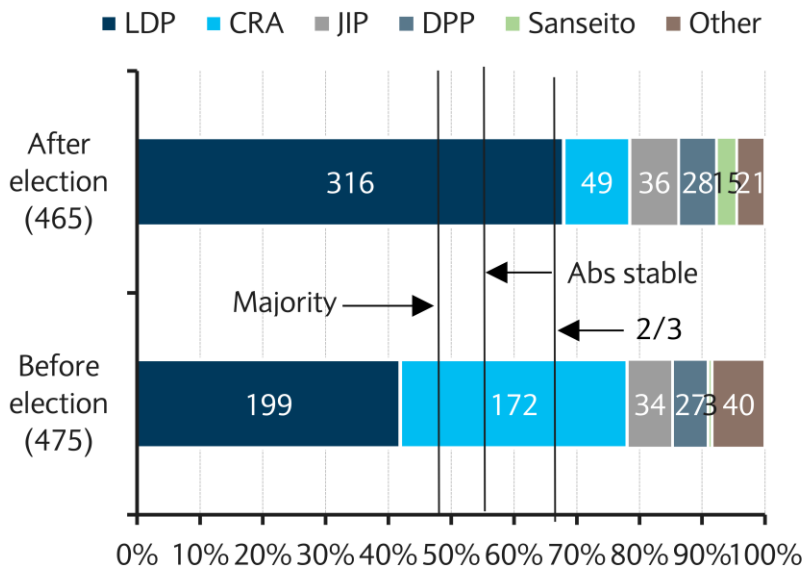
- We expect the next rate hike in April, followed by October and April 2027, for a 1.5% terminal
  - A March hike is only likely in the event of sharp JPY depreciation, with the 160 level at risk
  - Public frustration with cost-push inflation, as well as US pressure, all argue against a slower BoJ cycle
  - ***Overall, we don't expect Japan policy to upset the current balance that the market has settled into***

- Meanwhile, Chinese disinflation continues, with headline CPI at 0.2% y/y in January from 0.8% in December
  - Part of the weakness is admittedly the timing of the Chinese New Year holiday week, but only part
  - On the other hand, gold imports boosted the print; without it, inflation would likely have been -0.1% to -0.2% y/y
  - We maintain our below-consensus CPI forecast of 0.4% for 2026, given housing deflation and weak demand

[1] Global Economics Weekly: Sensory overload (13 February 2026)

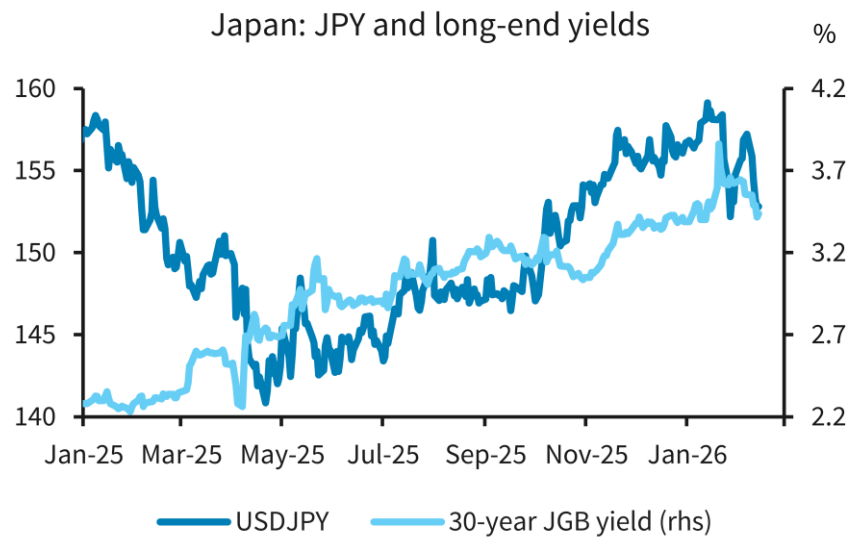
JPY and long-end JGBs have rallied since Japan's election

Takaichi's LDP secured a two-thirds majority in the Lower House of the Diet



Source: Lower house, Barclays Research
Global Economics Weekly: Sensory overload (13 February 2026)

The JPY and JGBs rallied in the days after, as markets expect the LDP to now feel less pressure for additional fiscal easing



Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research
Global Economics Weekly: Sensory overload (13 February 2026)

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Making sense of it all

- We turned bullish risk assets last week, after three weeks on the sidelines
  - The call hasn't worked yet; the S&P and Nasdaq were both slightly lower on the week
  - But the AI fear trade increasingly seems to be running on irrational narratives [1]

- CHRW was a good example of illogical AI fears [2]
  - The logistics stock touched an all-time high the week before last, but collapsed last week
  - The catalyst was a new AI tool by RIME – a karaoke machine firm that now has AI trucking software
  - Meanwhile, CHRW's bonds held up quite well; the equity move seems purely sentiment-driven

- This, in our view, is indicative of much of the sell-off in the last two weeks
  - As a new AI tool is released, it routinely sparks selling in related services sectors
  - The selling has now spread from tech to wealth managers, insurance companies, communications, etc

- We believe this move is severely overdone at this point, and a buying opportunity
  - While AI will disrupt existing business models, the winners and losers are far from certain
  - Moreover, AI will also lead to opportunities for many firms, on both the top- and bottom-line

- Market breadth remains positive, with more than half the S&P above its 200dma
  - A number of market-moving 'events' out of the way, JPY/JGBs have stabilized and US data is better
  - This Friday could see the Supreme Court decision on IEEPA; either a neutral or a positive for risk

- ***We remain overweight risk assets, and also stay with our call to be long the US 3y point*** [3]
  - Finally, we stay with our US steepeners view, despite the rally in longer duration last week

[1] Equity Market Review: Sell first, ask later (13 February 2026)
[2] AI disintermediation fears coming from a small AI start-up; Buy CHRW, Barclays Research (12 February 2026)
[3] Global Rates Weekly: It's complicated (12 February 2026)

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Selected research

- Global Economics Weekly: Sensory overload (13 February 2026)
- US Economics: January CPI: Downside surprise masks tariff pressures underneath (13 February 2026)
- Global Rates Weekly: It's complicated (12 February 2026)
- US Economics: January employment: Surprise, surprise (11 February 2026)
- US Economics: What K-shape? (10 February 2026)
- U.S. Equity Strategy: Food for Thought: Sectors Pay Heed to Payrolls (13 February 2026)
- Equity Market Review: Sell first, ask later (13 February 2026)
- European Equity Strategy: How to play AI dislocation? (11 February 2026)
- Earnings Season Watch: Earnings recovery on track (12 February 2026)

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